

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Mehdi Girach

Address: 104A Burdon Lane Cheam SM2 7DA

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am a local resident writing in support of the proposed change of use from the former ambulance station on Dorset Road to a mixed-use Place of Worship (Class F1) and Community Hub (Class F2).

This proposal represents the positive reuse of an existing site. The building is already in community-related use, and this application seeks to continue serving the public through worship, education, and broader community activities. Retaining and improving an existing structure is preferable to vacancy or deterioration and aligns with sustainable development principles.

Traffic and School Pick Up Concerns:

The daily prayer times are spread throughout the day and do not coincide with school drop off and pick up times. The short duration of prayers and the distribution of attendance across five daily prayer times mean that visitor flow is staggered rather than concentrated.

In addition:

- Attendance at daily prayer is typically modest, with larger gathering mainly limited to Friday lunchtime.
- Friday prayers occur during working hours, when general residential parking pressure is lower.
- The proposal includes cycle storage, encouraging sustainable travel.
- Many worshippers are likely to be local residents who will walk.

The traffic profile of a place of worship differs significantly from venues that generate concentrated evening or weekend surges.

Community Benefit and Youth Engagement:

The inclusion of Class F2 (Community Hub) use is important. The property will not function solely as a place of worship, but as a structured environment for:

- Youth activities
- Educational support and mentoring
- Social development programmes
- Community events and wellbeing initiatives

Providing constructive, supervised spaces for young people strengthens social cohesion and reduces antisocial behaviour. A well-managed community hub benefits the wider area, not just congregants.

Community Resilience and Social Infrastructure:

Modern planning increasingly recognises the importance of social infrastructure, facilities that strengthen community networks and resilience.

Places of worship and community hubs often:

- Coordinate volunteer networks
- Provide charitable initiatives
- Offer mental wellbeing support
- Assist vulnerable residents during periods of hardship

The COVID 19 pandemic highlighted the importance of trusted local institutions. Facilities like this serve as stabilising anchors within neighbourhoods, reducing pressure on statutory services and strengthening social cohesion.

This proposal enhances Belmont's social infrastructure in a structured, managed way.

Public Health and Wellbeing:

Places of worship and community hubs contribute to mental health and wellbeing by reducing loneliness and fostering belonging. Social isolation is a recognised public health issue. A well managed, welcoming space where people can gather responsibly supports preventative wellbeing outcomes.

Planning is not only about buildings, it is about creating healthy communities.

Environmental Sustainability and Localism:

The site serves a local catchment. Many worshippers are likely to live within walking distance. Encouraging local access to worship and community facilities reduces the need for longer journeys elsewhere.

The inclusion of cycle storage demonstrates commitments to sustainable transport. Reusing an

existing building also reduces the carbon impact associated with demolition and full redevelopment.

Established Community and Worship Use in the Area:

It is also relevant that places of worship already operate within the wider Belmont area, demonstrating that such uses are compatible with the surrounding residential character. The proposal therefore does not introduce an unfamiliar land use, but continues an established pattern of community and faith based facilities serving local residents.

Noise and Disturbance:

There is no proposal for externally amplified calls to prayer. Prayer services are orderly and quiet. Worshippers typically arrive and leave in a respectful and gradual manner, and there is no reason to assume prolonged outdoor congregation or disturbance.

Compared with other uses permitted within Class F1 or F2, a place of worship is relatively low impact in terms of noise and disturbance.

Investment and Site Improvement:

The proposal includes a part one, part two-storey extension and improvements that will enhance the appearance and functionality of the building. Provision for refuse and cycle storage indicates thoughtful design and responsible operation. This is a long-term investment into a currently underutilised site.

Economic and Civic Contribution:

Faith and community institutions often:

- Employ local contractors
- Support local suppliers
- Organise charitable fundraising and outreach

This contributes positively to the local micro-economy and civic life.

Conclusion:

This proposal represents:

- Sustainable reuse of an existing building
- Managed activity patterns
- Youth and community development opportunities
- Strengthening of local social infrastructure
- Investment in the built environment
- Support for wellbeing and cohesion
- Low-impact operational characteristics

For these reasons, I respectfully urge the Council to approve this application.